SpeechGeek



Season Five: Nationals 2008

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After hours upon end in coaching sessions, weekend after weekend on the road here and there for tournaments, Sunday afternoons spent reading ballots, and lots of "Why do I keep doing this season after season?", we find ourselves nearing the end of another competitive season of forensics.

If we didn't love this activity so much, we wouldn't continue to do it, would we?

This activity is more than the trophies, respect of peers, and the occasional pat on the back from a school administrator. It's about knowing that the skills young people develop in this activity will serve them for the rest of their lives. It's knowing the friendships they make will carry on for years. It's about having fun.

As always, **SpeechGeek** is honored to be a part of your school's program. We will continue to publish quality performance material in future seasons and appreciate your patronage.

Corey Alderdice
Publisher



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Mixed Up

by Meredith Stein

My mother and father had a mixed marriage – a rarity for the small Midwestern town they grew up in. My dad was Jewish and my mom was Catholic. It wasn't a big deal to my immediate family. We weren't particularly religious growing up. They didn't try to convert each other or their children, so it was all – how would my grandma put it? – "kosher." My Dad wasn't even practicing, although that would be headline news to his parents. We lived near a Catholic church, so my mom and I went there. I was baptized, confirmed and raised Catholic. I was a Catholic. And my Dad didn't love me any less.

The only problem was my Jewish grandmother. She had no idea that my mom and I weren't Jewish. You see my mother promised to convert when my parents were dating – a little white lie between her and my father. I only saw my father's mother once a year, if that often, so it wasn't hard to keep it a secret. But no matter what, I couldn't tell her that my mom and I were Catholic.

When grandman finally died, I was upset but also relieved in a way because I thought that maybe all of the hiding was over. I thought that maybe Dad and Mom would finally be free to love each other for who they were and be proud of it. No more secrets. Most importantly, I figured that I'd never have to deal with that kind of bigotry again--at least in my family. But, like curly hair and weird ears and heart disease, I guess some of that stuff is hereditary.

Let me tell you what's not hereditary – a mind that understands and appreciates the wonderful world of science. My mom is a nurse practitioner. She loves biology and anatomy and all of that junk that makes no sense to me whatsoever. And my Dad is some sort of researcher in some sort of science lab. I don't even know what he does. But they love science. And me - I'm not a science girl. In fact, my scientific expertise extends to about the fourth grade, when I got an honorable mention in the science fair because my mom did my project.

Now that I think about it, it really wasn't that complicated of a project. All I was doing was examining geraniums in sugar water and geraniums in regular water to see which would grow faster. Not that complicated in hindsight – but worthy of my mother walking me through it every step of the way. I maybe could have won the thing, but I had no idea what was going on when the judges tried to ask me about the photosynthesis cycles in plants and sugar waters effect. To this day, I still have no idea what photosynthesis is. Clearly, I was a fourth grade faker.

Still, my parents really wanted me to take high school chemistry because my guidance counselor said it would be important for college. They made me sign up for chemistry with Mrs.Wilcox, the only teacher in my school who even taught chemistry. Trust me, this child was left behind. It was pretty much the lamest class I'd ever had. The woman could hardly stay awake to teach it and I wasn't about to wake her. The only bright spot was my friend, Marcus. We were in band together, so I knew him before I took chemistry. But he played trumpet and I played the flute, so our contact was limited by the woodwind and brass divide.

However, both of us were geeks to the core. Once class started, though, I was kicking myself for not getting to know him sooner. We were more alike than different. We were both a little too sarcastic for our own good, especially in high

school. We were the same age and had grown up, unknowingly, just a few blocks apart.

Marcus made chemistry not only bearable, but almost fun. We sat by each other in class and played games to pass the hour. We invented new names for each other and only called each other by those names. Let's see – his name for me was Ingrid Imogene Oprah Jones and my name for him was Lenny Quintaro Quimblidaryowitz. We passed notes with the funniest jokes we could think of, trying to make each other laugh out loud. I remember this one time he drew this hilarious picture of Mrs. Wilcox with her hair on fire from the Bunsen burner. He called it Death by Chemistry. Hilarious stuff. We even pretended to be brother and sister during twin day for the Student Council's spirit week – which didn't work too well, because Marcus was black and I was white. "I'm her brother from another mother, fool!" Marcus would say with a slight grin to anyone that would question the likelihood of our relation. "I'm his sister from another mister!" I would say. It sounded less cool coming from my mouth.

From time to time, when my mom asked about school, I would mention Marcus and our crazy times in Chemistry. He was just so fun! I could tell that she was annoyed that I goofed off so much in class, but she didn't say anything. She just pursed her lips and looked away. What do you expect, though? My mom was good at chemistry. And me…I just wasn't my mother.

One day I walked into chemistry and took my cursory seat in the back next to Marcus. He was sitting on the back of his chair talking to the senior at the table in front of us. "That's what I'm telling you," I overheard him say. "There are dead bodies in the supply closet, that's why this place is so cold." The senior boy rolled his eyes and turned away. Marcus shrugged. "His loss," he said intentionally loudly. I played along. "Yeah, he's going to be sorry about that when he winds up in the back room," I said.

The bell rang and Mrs. Wilcox walked in and stood behind the lab table at the front of the room. "For this next unit, you're going to need a partner," she began in her droll, nasal voice. Marcus and I immediately turned to each other. We had to come up with a way to show the distance between the sun, Earth, and moon in proportion using a model. Marcus passed me a crumpled up note. "Now what does that have to do with chemistry?" he asked. "Is she making this stuff up? Shouldn't we be memorizing the periodic table or something?"

I penciled my reply casually, trying to make it seem like I was taking notes. "Maybe she always secretly wanted to teach kindergarten, and that's why she wants to grade a bunch of finger-paint projects."

He read it under the table and passed it back. "Maybe she's actually an alien, and she needs more information about space to transmit to her mothership," it said.

"Maybe she's probably giving us busy work so she can focus on hiding the bodies in the supply closet." I scribbled furiously.

"Mmm-hmm," he loudly. Mrs. Willcox looked up, but she couldn't seem to tell where the noise came from. The senior in front of us started laughing. I got cold chills, because as much as I like to pretend that I'm a rebel, I don't like to get in trouble.

After class, I told Marcus to come over to my house to work on the project. "You don't' think your parents will care?" He asked. "No way," I said. "My mom loves science. Trust me, its fine." Marcus closed his Trapper Keeper. "Okay," he said, "I'll get my mom to bring me over."

After school I told my mom that I needed to go to Wal-Mart to get

supplies for my chemistry project. "Marcus and I have to show the distance between the sun, the Earth, and the moon. To scale," I added. She turned left out of the school parking lot to go to the grocery store. "Do we have to go get him?" she asked. I shook my head. "His mom is bringing him." I still remember my mother pursing her lips and staring ahead at the road. The minutes seem to go by slow in our car that day. "You've got to help me make dinner before he comes over, if you're going to have him over" she said. I rolled my eyes. Marcus was not coming over to eat. Parents have no idea sometimes about what's important. "I think he's coming after dinner, Mom," I explained. "Well, then I guess you'd better have everything cleaned up by the time he gets here."

So we went to the grocery store, then home, where I helped my mother make spaghetti badly. She's a great cook, but…like science….I just didn't inherit the gene. I was doing something I figured I couldn't screw up – stirring the noodles – when she said from across the room, "I'm a little concerned about how much time you are spending with Marcus." I glanced over at her, but she was looking down at the French bread she was cutting. "You've got to be kidding me," I said. "This guy is great!" She kept right on sawing away at the French bread. "It's not that we mind you and he being friends…it's just that your father and I – we don't want people to think that you are dating."

I went back to stirring the spaghetti. "Well, we aren't dating, first of all," I told her. "Besides, why do you care? He's a straight A student. He's a nice guy." Mom put down the serrated knife. "Well, I don't care, but you know how some people are, especially around here. They just don't believe in interracial relationships. People aren't as… progressive…as you might think, honey." I got cold chills. I stopped stirring the spaghetti. "Are you telling me I can't be friends with one of my best friends, because he is black?" Mom carried the bread over to the table.

"You can be his friend," she said, not bothering to look at me. "Just be careful, that's all I'm saying. Your reputation is important." And then I lost it. "How is my relationship with Marcus any different than your relationship with dad? You and dad were different and you told me growing up that differences are what makes us stronger."

"Honey, there is a big difference between being Jewish and being of another race."

"How?"

"Black and white should not mix. It just makes things complicated. I'm sure Marcus' mother feels the same way that I do. Think about your future, here. And if you won't – I will. I just don't want others to think that you've gone down the wrong track, that's all."

"I can't believe this!" I shouted, half hurt and half angry. "You're racist!"

Mom's words back to me were like ice. "Go to your room, young lady."

It was that day that I learned that racism is still alive and kicking me in the butt. I thought racism tales were a thing of the past; something that people like my grandma held onto because they were old and scarred by the world. But, today, in my kitchen making overcooked spaghetti – it was very real. As much as I didn't want to, I cried in my room that day. Not for getting in trouble and hurting my mother's feelings. I wasn't even crying for the pain and the mistreatment Marcus must often go through on a daily basis. After all, he was probably used to it without me ever realizing. I was crying that the black cloud called racism was still looming over me – over everyone. See, back in the day, people like my grandma didn't know right from wrong. But today people ought to know the difference and they still choose to hate someone just because of the color of

their skin. I think that is what made me cry the most.

I was nursing my eyes with Visine when Marcus's mom pulled up in the driveway. He eased out of the car comfortably, backpack over one shoulder and the omnipresent trapper keeper in the bend of his arm. I let him into the house and led him into the kitchen. Mom and Dad greeted him with pretentious smiles and went to another room. Marcus didn't care.

As we started setting up the supplies for our planet project, Marcus said, "You look more like your mom than your dad." He uncapped the paint.

"That's because my Dad's Jewish," I blurted out. "Did I ever tell you that they had a mixed marriage?"

"No," he said, pouring a dab of red paint onto a paper plate. "Let's make the sun orange."

"Okay," I said, pouring a spot of yellow next to the red. "Anyway, my Dad's Jewish and my Mom's Catholic. We couldn't ever tell my grandma that we weren't Jewish. It was a really big deal."

Marcus laughed without looking up. "That's messed up," he said, handing me a brush.

"Tell me about it," I said, mixing the colors quietly.

Could've Been Worse

by Trevor Anders

"Tell me about yourself," she said. I thought this was kind of odd considering how formal this interview had become. Because let's face it, I'm not great at job interviews. It's easy to think that you're qualified for say...a blind date until the woman across the table seriously wants you to pass a resume her way.

"Well, I'm a writer." I say.

I always like saying this phrase. I imagine the great authors of history meeting new people. When they announce themselves as wordmongers conversational jaws drop to the floor. Their audiences respond, "Of course we know who you are Lord Byron. Might I say I love...(please insert title here)."

"Have you been published?" she replies, a look a skepticism sketched across her brow.

"Not exactly. I mean, I've sent some stuff off, but nothing's quite in print...yet."

"I guess you're not very good at it then."

Let's mentally pause for a moment, shall we? Being a writer isn't about paychecks and Nobel Prizes, well, yet. Being is writer is about the craft and the love for the art. Because if my words could feed me, I would have died from gluttony years ago. I've known Shelly now for thirty minutes and I can already tell this date will end like most of them:

Me excusing myself to the restroom and then climbing out the window.

No.

Me crawling under the table and digging a hole to China.

No.

Me signing my name across the bill for dinner and leaving the restaurant only to return home physically and mentally unfulfilled.

I take in a deep breath. "Well, Shelly, that's only by day. Actually, I'm a multibillionaire whose parents were tragically murdered when I was a toddler. In all honesty, I fight crime at night—roaming the streets to purge the city of scum. And while thirteen old ladies have either been murdered or robbed during our little conversation, I've weighed the consequences of my prioritizing and, guess what, you came out on top. How does that make you feel?"

By this time I'm breathing rapidly as sweat collects against the back of my starched collar. I glance around the room. The clanging sounds of silver and glass have momentarily stopped. Even the sound of the piano in the background is missing. That's when I realize that every set of eyes are looking at me. I've done it again. I am the fool and we're not evening talking the Shakespearean kind that offers insight to the protagonist at his or her most vital moment. No, that would be too generous. Instead, I am the idiotic rambler who cannot keep his words in check.

This is probably why Shelly does not consider me a writer or as a candidate for a second date.

"I don't need this," Shelly announces as she quickly rises from her seat not even showing enough care to place her napkin on the table. Instead, she throws it in my face. I slump backwards deeper into my chair in the four-year-old kind of way that would have me believe I've disappeared. Instead, I just become more conspicuous.

Thank goodness my best friend Jeff is part of the waiting staff at the restau-

rant. Jeff is almost a carbon copy of my empty self, dark hair and unusually average looks. We both have that look of a fresh college graduate who clearly has the mark of spending the past four years in meaningful study of the humanities only to be unable to find gainful employment. Yet there is something optimistic in his swagger this evening.

"Well, that could've been worse," he bubbles.

"You could sound a little less optimistic."

"Think about it, she could have shouted that you have back-acne to the entire room. She could've said that you were wearing ladies' underwear. She could've said you have a vast collection of Highlights Magazines. She could've…"

"Fine, you made your point."

Jeff sits down at my table-for-two. He leans back as if to announce his sinister plans for world domination, his fingers interlaced against his mandatory clip on bow-tie. He begins to smirk as he takes in a deep breath to speak. It is at this moment that I remember why Jeff is my friend.

We each react differently in situations of this nature.

"So you had a bad date, who cares?"

I begin to chuckle. "At least we were only to the appetizers portion of the evening," as I scoop more artichoke dip onto my piece of bread. Rationalization usually helps. I'm desperately making my attempt at returning to the status quo. Yes, the dinner could have gone past appetizers. It could have ended in *"and they lived happily ever after in suburban bliss,"* but there will be plenty of time for sulking later.

"She really didn't even have straight teeth. I swear I've seen better grills at a tailgate."

Jeff and I are in the middle of a fine family dining establishment and it feels as though we're sitting on the couch at our apartment eating nachos and watching the latest installment of The Daily Show. And I'm beginning to realize there are more important things going on right now than bad first dates.

"Uh, shouldn't you be getting back to work?" My own words catch me off guard. After all, I've never been one to have a good work ethic.

"Oh, right. Hey, I'll see you later this evening. Better yet, let me get your check."

Jeff returns to the table with the leather folder in hand and quickly exits through the double doors of the kitchen. I open the mini-folio and can't help but grin as my glance falls toward the final tab.

$6.66.

That's pretty good for two appetizers at your friendly neighborhood J.B. Shenanigan's Steakhouse and Cattle Emporium. Scribbled at the bottom of the receipt are the words *You'll get 'em next time, champ!*.

The evening still looks promising

Cutting Cords

by Trevor Anders

When you look at things from a purely technical perspective, the process is rather simple: a telephone conversation is simply the product of impulses. Physical impulses become electrical impulses beamed from one side of the world to the other. It sounds simple enough, though it stands to reason there are scientific actualities that leave the process purely uncomprehendable. It isn't a problem that the older brother is in his rural Kentucky home and the younger brother is at a truck stop somewhere in the middle of England. After all, distance doesn't matter, at least from a technical standpoint. However, science has little to do with the truth of the matter. From a less than technical standpoint, the younger brother would rather deny his impulse to speak with the older on this pivotal day.

The younger would rather strangle his sibling than say I love you, but impulses can be deceiving. So he follows against better judgment and begins the dialing the process–each digit one moment closer to facing reality. It's hard to get away from your twin because, well, you're a twin. Two souls connected since birth with a cord of flesh sharing the same space, living the same life. In the minds of other people you are always one in the same. Even family members have trouble associating the proper name with the correct twin. You dress the same, you sleep in the same room, eat the same meals, share the same friends, classmates, birthdays. You are, in fact, the only person who views yourself as a unique individual.

But eventually you have to start making your own decisions, becoming an individual. The older brother falls in love and decides to get married. The younger brother heads off to England to escape his closed-in little world. The older brother announces one-month earlier that he will be getting married when the younger is out of the country. The younger refuses to come home to cater to the older's plan. Each is a decision made of impulses that have brought the twins to this telephone conversation.

It goes without saying the twins had a stressed relationship. Twins are supposed to be the same person, right? Well, identical twins. Fraternal twin, as these were, only had a tendency to share confined spaces such as full sized beds and wombs. That was not the concern on this autumn afternoon/morning (depending on which side of the world you were on). The twins had all the space the wanted/needed from each other.

"I love you and I, uh, I'm really proud of you," the younger brother claims.

There is a pause from the older brother. Conversations like this one came rarely during the twins' formative years. Despite their genetic similarities, they had become completely different individuals. The older was the more pragmatic of the two, skilled in mechanics and nature. The younger was more bohemian, who played more with words than the metal replica tractors of his counterpart.

"Thanks. I'm sorry you couldn't be here," glosses the older brother. The younger brother is ironically left to question this statement. If the older were truly sorry, he would not have scheduled this affair for today. He would have waited, but you have to make your own decisions.

"Well, you know." The younger feels a non-committal remark here would be the best option.

"Yeah, so where are you?"

"I don't have a clue. A gas station in the middle of England. That would be my best guess. I see chips, soda, and petrol...there's grass outside too and a road. Otherwise, your guess is as good as mine." It would have been better to ask how are you. That question would have received a far more jaded response.

The younger brother realizes just how forced this conversation has become. While the doctor may have cut the cord that connected the twins, their mother always found a way to keep them together. When in chaotic environments, such as Wal-Mart, she would place a Velcro band around each of their wrists connected with a piece of telephone cord that kept the two boys close. Each brother would pull in the other direction as hard as he could trying to gain his emancipation from the other. (It would have been much easier to simply remove the Velcro.) But you don't realize that when you are four.

When you're twenty, well, that's a whole different perspective. The younger brother cannot show his true resent at the older brother's decision. They were connected by phone cords then. They were connected by phone cords now. Yet running never helps. The impulse that would pull them back together no matter how hard they ran in the other direction then was relatively the same impulse that pulled them back together now.

Because twins are inseparable.

When you look at it from a purely technical perspective, the harder one object pulls from its source, the harder it comes back...simple science. Yet it isn't so simple to say what you really want. However, the younger brother doesn't have much time left in this conversation. He has to catch the last leg of his connection back to his temporary home.

(sides story)

"Dammit. I want you to do me a favor, okay?" requests the younger.

"Sure," replies the older, a sense of confusion in his tone.

"I want you to put a photo of me in your pocket today, all right? I want to be able to be there with you. You know that, right? I just want to be able to up there with you. You'll do that?"

"Um, yeah. Yeah, I'll do that."

"But don't tell anyone. I'd hate for mom to know I'm not mad at you. Look, I gotta go. Best of luck, and uh, don't do or say anything stupid. I love you."

"I love you, too."

"Bye."

The impulse to hang up the phone doesn't arrive. Instead, it is met with another electrical impulse, the tone of an empty phone line. And yet the younger brother stands at the pay phone dumbfounded for the longest time.

These are the two twin brothers.

Separated in birth by minutes.

Separated in life by choices.

Separated in distance by an ocean.

Yet still connected with a cord.

Growing Up Girl

by Julia Nava

Program Theme

It isn't easy growing up as a girl in America. Between trying to make the grade, win the game, and get the friends, girls are faced with an oppressive pressure to acheive perfection. By examining the struggle to be herself, we are able to empathize with what modern girls face on the path to adulthood.

I Write Lullabies for Working Women

Once upon a time,
there was a girl named Goodwyn,
but her parents called her Goodie,
who was
    let's face it
just like every other girl
searching for her own piece of the world
to twist twirl and curl around
her little finger of ambition.
But for the meantime
Goodie was getting by just fine
with her B.A. in English
one bedroom apartment
and job as an editor for a
moderately progressive publication.
Her job was nice.
Her coworkers were nice.
Her apartment was nice.
Her life was nice
    which was all she
thought she wanted at the end of the day.

So when she met a nice guy,
by the name of Mr. Nuff he said –
    Call me Justin Nuff
and so she did.
They went on several dates
and always had a nice time.
They fell in love,
had a nice wedding
and became husband and wife.
Mister and Missus
Justin and Goodie Nuff.
They moved into a nice three bedroom house,
decorated it in whites and lived
a nice little life.
Goodie slept on piles of pillows

ate pastel pink marshmallows
played in her padded, pallid palace
and stayed away from things
that weren't very nice,
from the sharp jagged edges of
everything she didn't know
and never tried - denied the fact
that scars aren't a history of injury
but the footnotes of ambition
that teach the body to stretch beyond
it's own borders.

But since she was always safe,
Goodie never grew,
days tumbled into years and soon
she began to shrink
till she woke one morning and cried
I think I'm beginning to
Disappear!
"My dear honey dumpling"
Justin replied
"Why should my Goodie Nuff wife
be so filled with strife?
Haven't I given you a
Goodie Nuff life?"

With that
she began to shrink before his eyes
and all the pressure that had
been pressing down on her
pushed the words from
her lungs to her lips:
I can no longer breathe
with all of this ordinary
suffocating me!
I don't want to settle for
a Goodie Nuff life.
I don't want to be a honey bee
Who never left the hive!
I don't want to die a sparrow
Who never swam the sky!
I want things I never knew I needed
I want to see the trees
Throw me their leaves because
It's the closest they have to confetti
I want to feel the tingly
Breeze on my cheeks
Because the clouds are blowing me kisses
I don't want to settle for being amused
I need to be the muse
That makes artists kiss the ground I walk on

With enough passion
To turn earth-gasms into earthquakes
making the tectonic plates shake
and fault-lines break open
so the ground can sigh...Wow.
I need to know that if life is a beach
that I'm the view of the sea
and not just the sand beneath your feet.

But then,
Goodie Nuff saw Justin Nuff's brow crinkle
like a wrinkled candy wrapper.
She said,
I'm sorry – my love
While I love being your wife,
I don't think I want a
Goodie Nuff life.

And that suffocating pain she felt before
evaporated,
her muscles awakened
her spine straightened and
Goodie grew
into someone new,
someone taller, stronger
and smarter than anyone ever knew.

The moral of this story,
should be plain to the eye:
don't ever
ever
ever
let yourself settle
for a good enough life.

Sharks Swim with More Honesty

"Whoever wrote,
'It's not easy being green'
Should take a shot
At being thirteen"
The Southfield Heights Junior High
Gym teacher jokes
Unrolling the poster with scrolled words:
WELCOME TO WOMANHOOD.
20 lungs heave heavy sighs
While 40 rolling eyes fall on the teacher
Who reassures
"It gets easier"
One girl is smart enough to know it's not true
And kind enough to keep it to herself

In this tiny pond
She is a koi
Surrounded by countless goldfish
For whom beauty and similarity are synonymous
They must be called cliques
Because of clicking compacts,
Clicking heels
Clicking teeth
She finds herself flanked by *them*
Pony-tailed, polished pink
Specimens of puberty
Preening, plucking, primping
Goldfish on display

The koi isnt built like that,
her body,
a novel for the blind
begging for fingertips
to trace rounded curves and bumps
translating a gorgeous brilliance
the eye cannot understand.
her body is a romance language
dripping off a tongue
that never tasted Western lips

because there are no words in the English language
designed to describe her.
her wide hips roll with a fluidity
that taught water how to move
her face is a Botticelli dream
so rounded and soft
that turning the other cheek
should be a compliment
while goldfish ricochet through halls
frenzied darting, jumping
she moves with a graceful weight of conviction
inconspicuously swimming with the school
each day of survival
a triumph
tells herself
"It gets easier"
finds comfort
in lies she tells herself
and looks from men
old enough to be her father.

Bells ring and they retreat to the locker room
The mirror
a magnifying lens for goldfish
Bodies become dissertations in science
striving for precision
weighing and measuring
arms too soft,
thighs too wide,
skin too pale
observe
record results
sigh heavy
alter variables
eat less
run more
repeat tomorrow
hope for change

In this tiny pond
Her reflection is a sonnet
Scribbled by a love-struck sophomore:
Aiming for classical, breaking convention
Missing the target but never the point.
But poetry has betrayed her
Some bubbles sink

In this tiny pond
The water isn't fit for floatation
Rising above it was designed for
Mythological heroes
Whose only worries were
Cycloptic monsters,
When the thin, pretty, blonde ones
Are far deadlier.
One day
When she's older
She'll look back and forgive
She'll look back and see herself
For what she was, not everything she wasn't.
Wisdom is luxury reserved for the future
Today is different
In the locker room
She sinks
Like a stone in seaweed
when she hears them say
I'd rather be dead
than fat.

Memory Drive

by Michael Hix and Will Schuster

Program Theme
Human beings are driven by memory--either the need to rely on it for day to day activities or to shape their personal history and identity. So what happens when our memory fails us ("Malfunction") or is incomplete ("Ghosts").

I Don't Mean to Malfunction
by Michael Hix

I'm sorry.

You'll have to forgive me.

I would be more insightful

Were I not so short-sighted.

Or is it near-sighted?

You see...

(no pun intended)

My mind is filled with these blind spots

And forgotten thoughts

Places where my brain presses stop

Rewind

Delete

Fast-forward

Repeat

Wait...where-were-we...?

Forget about that...what I mean is –

It's always an accident

There's spilled milk on my amygdala

From ideas accumulated

Throughout the day

I'm an absent minded professor

So enamored in the sterility of my lab

I can fumble and mumble around

Till I stumble on sound discoveries like flubber

While forgetting my lover at the altar

And some sunny afternoons I leave from work

And miss the same turn I've taken

Everyday for the past ten years

I'll go for weeks without checking my mail

Until it dog piles on itself, leaving

Bills and catalogues to squirm beneath

My frenzied hands scribbling past-due checks

Yet no matter how many times

I pick up the phone to call you

I pause

And stare at the numbers

As if I were looking for a contact lens

At the bottom of a swimming pool

I always have that same thought:

If I don't jump in

I won't drown

My mind makes me forget your number

My brain eats my thoughts

My memory makes me pick and choose

Lining up daily routines

Perfect metaphors

And reminders to pick up the gift

For our anniversary

So I'm sorry.

You deserve someone who remembers that

You love daffodils.

Not dandelions

Your birthday is the 12th

Not the 21st

And that when your mother forgot

To pick you up from soccer practice

When you were nine you swore you'd

Never forget what it feels like to be forgotten.

So I'm sorry

All I can say is that

I'll try to remember next time.

Giving Up the Ghost
by Will Schuster

Growing up,
my mom and had
an unspoken bargain.
After every bite of dinner was consumed
once the trash has been disposed of
and homework completed
and tucked into Trapper Keepers
for safe keeping,
when I went to bed
she'd fill my mind
with fragments of a father
I barely knew.
They were ghost stories
for a man who wasn't dead
but whose intentional absences
from our lives
kept the halls of our home cold,
made me think I heard a ringing
phone with phantom calls from him
and made late night appearances in mirrors
as I'd be haunted by seeing his
eyes, nose or ears.
Once or twice a year
the ghost of my father took human form
stopping by for a friendly meal,
rattling chains with vague phrases
How's school?
Getting taller, I see.
Before disappearing again.

Most nights I'd sit alone
and conjure the ghost
of my living father
with whatever my mother told me.
He liked the smooth burn
of bourbon in his throat,
the first hour after he returned
from work was spent in silence
and he thought Ella spoke the language
of angels when she'd scat.
So I'd stretch my body
the length of my bed and
held seances for his spirit

I'd chant
a scat
ah skit-it-ee skat ah skit-it-ee skat
ah bip bom boo lee too lee
rat a tat
ah skit-it-ee skat ah skit-it-ee skat
ah bip bom boo lee too lee
rat a tat
ah kiss ka tat
ah kiss ka dat
ah kiss ka dad
I miss my dad

I miss my dad.

When I stopped, I'd stare outside
at the moon, searching for
a celestial suggestion that somewhere
he too was speaking in tongues,
thinking of his haunted son,
possessed with making a connection.

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